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The Nuclear Dimension

The baton of the chairman of the chiefs of staff committee was handed over to me by Air Chief Marshal S.P. Tyagi in February 2007, and I held this position till I superannuated at the end of September that year. This committee is chartered to discuss and evolve joint military strategy focusing on national security challenges and to advise the national leadership on all service matters. During this period, three important events or issues took centre stage: a tri-service delegation led by me to China, the formulation of the recommendations of the armed forces to the 6th Pay Commission, and the implementation of the A.V. Singh Committee Part II report dealing with cadre review of senior ranks. These issues have been dealt with separately.

This was also the first occasion when one took a very close look at the nuclear component of national security. Though we had carried out a peaceful nuclear explosion (Pokharan I) in 1974, we had not demonstrated our capability of nuclear weaponization till the testing of five nuclear devices on 11 and 13 May 1998 (Pokharan II or Operation Shakti). It was in the wake of these tests that on 14 May 1998, Prime Minister Vajpayee stated, 'India is now a nuclear weapons state. We have the capacity for a big bomb now. Ours will never be weapons of aggression.'[1]

The nuclear dimension of India's national security strategy is based on the doctrine of a credible minimum nuclear deterrence, and our stated policy that there will be no first use of nuclear weapons, and that these will not be used against non-nuclear states. Our policy clearly lays down 'a continuance of strict controls on export of nuclear- and missile-related materials and technologies,